

Hacker Scoring Guide

Hack4Change · Greater Moncton Homelessness Steering Committee Challenge

This guide explains exactly how your project will be evaluated, what judges look for at each score level, and how you can maximise your score in every category. Use it throughout the hackathon — not just at the end. The best teams think about these criteria from the moment they define their problem.

How Your Score is Calculated

CRITERION	WEIGHT	IN PLAIN TERMS	SCORE
01 Impact	25%	Does it solve a real, meaningful problem for the GMHSC community?	/ 10
02 Feasibility	25%	Could it actually be built, deployed, and used beyond today?	/ 10
03 Innovation	15%	Is the approach creative, thoughtful, or meaningfully different?	/ 10
04 Technical Design	15%	Is it well-built, reliable, and clearly designed?	/ 10
05 User Experience	15%	Can the real intended user actually use it without help?	/ 10
06 Pitch	5%	Did the team communicate clearly and make judges believe in the solution?	/ 10

Remember: You don't need a perfect 10 in every category. A team that deeply understands their problem and clearly communicates their solution will consistently outperform a technically impressive team that loses the audience.

Impact

The most heavily weighted criterion — make sure your problem is real and your solution changes something.

Weight

25%

Impact is worth a quarter of your total score. Judges want to know: **does your solution fix something that genuinely matters** to people experiencing homelessness, frontline shelter workers, or the broader GMHSC community? A technically impressive solution that solves a trivial problem will score lower than a simpler solution that addresses a real, urgent need.

Score	Level	What judges will see at this level
1–3	Low	Problem is vague or minor. Judges cannot identify a clear community need or a meaningful change in people's lives.
4–7	Moderate	A real need is clearly identified and the solution would create positive change. Evidence of community awareness is present.
8–10	High	The team demonstrates deep knowledge of the problem, who it affects, and why it matters urgently. The solution has clear, measurable, lasting impact.

Tips for a strong score

- Open your pitch by naming the specific problem and who experiences it — not the technology.
- Use real numbers or stories if you have them (e.g., 'intake staff spend 40 min per client on paperwork').
- Connect your solution directly back to the problem. Don't leave judges guessing.
- Think about lives changed, not just features built.

Common pitfalls to avoid

- Don't lead with the tech — lead with the person it helps.
- Avoid vague language like 'help the community'. Be specific.
- Don't assume judges know the problem — explain it clearly even if it seems obvious.
- A solution in search of a problem will score very low here.

Self-Assessment Checklist — Before you submit, can you answer yes to all of these?

- We can name the specific problem and explain who is affected.
- We have evidence (observation, conversation, data) that this problem is real.
- We can describe the concrete change our solution creates in someone's daily life.
- Our solution directly addresses the identified problem — not just adjacent to it.
- We can explain why this problem matters to the GMHSC community specifically.

Feasibility asks: **could this be deployed and sustained in a real shelter or homelessness services environment?** This means thinking beyond the hackathon — who maintains it, what does it cost, what happens when something breaks, and does it fit how frontline staff actually work? Ambitious ideas are encouraged, but they need a believable path to reality.

Score	Level	What judges will see at this level
1–3	Low	The solution is impractical, relies on unavailable resources, or skips over major implementation barriers. No clear path to deployment.
4–7	Moderate	The solution could work with reasonable effort and planning. Core approach is sound, though some operational details need refinement.
8–10	High	Thoroughly planned and operationally grounded. Team has considered training, maintenance, cost, and privacy. Could be piloted quickly.

Tips for a strong score

- Describe a realistic first deployment: where, by whom, and with what support.
- Acknowledge constraints (budget, internet access, staff capacity) and explain how you've accounted for them.
- Mention what happens after the hackathon — does your solution need ongoing maintenance?
- If you used existing tools or platforms, explain why that makes it more practical.

Common pitfalls to avoid

- Don't assume unlimited budget, perfect internet, or technical staff at the shelter.
- Avoid hand-waving deployment — 'it just needs to be set up' is not enough.
- Don't ignore data privacy — shelters handle sensitive resident information.
- Overengineered solutions often score lower than simple ones that actually work.

Self-Assessment Checklist — Before you submit, can you answer yes to all of these?

- We can describe where and how this would be deployed after the hackathon.
- We have considered what happens when something goes wrong (support, maintenance).
- We have thought about who trains staff and how long it would take.
- Our solution works within realistic constraints (budget, connectivity, devices).
- Data privacy and resident confidentiality have been addressed.
- A non-technical person could understand how to use and maintain this solution.

Innovation

You don't need to invent something new — you need to solve the problem in a way that's genuinely thoughtful.

Weight

15%

Innovation doesn't require a brand-new technology. It can mean applying a familiar tool in an unexpected way, combining existing solutions cleverly, or reframing a problem that others have overlooked. **Judges are looking for creative thinking and original perspective** — evidence that your team explored the problem space rather than jumping to the first obvious answer.

Score	Level	What judges will see at this level
1–3	Low	Predictable solution that mirrors existing tools with no meaningful twist. The team appears to have chosen the first obvious approach.
4–7	Moderate	Thoughtful approach showing the team considered alternatives. Some creative adaptation or clever combination of ideas is evident.
8–10	High	Genuinely inventive. The idea reframes the problem, surprises in a good way, or applies tools in a way that isn't obvious. Shows real creative risk.

Tips for a strong score

- Briefly explain the alternatives you considered and why you chose your approach.
- If your solution feels obvious, ask yourself: what makes ours different or better?
- Connecting ideas from different domains (e.g., applying a retail tool to shelter intake) scores well.
- Show your thinking process — judges value the journey, not just the destination.

Common pitfalls to avoid

- Building a CRUD app or basic dashboard without a twist won't score highly here.
- Don't confuse complexity with innovation — clever and simple is often better.
- Don't copy an existing tool without showing how you've adapted or improved it.
- Saying 'we used AI' is not innovative by itself — explain what's novel about your use.

Self-Assessment Checklist — Before you submit, can you answer yes to all of these?

- We considered at least 2–3 different approaches before settling on ours.
- We can explain what makes our solution different from what already exists.
- There is at least one element of our solution that would surprise or impress judges.
- We made a deliberate design choice — not just the first thing that came to mind.
- Our innovation serves the user — it's not just technically clever for its own sake.

Technical Design evaluates **how well-built and well-thought-out your solution is**. For working prototypes, this means code quality, architecture, and how the system handles real-world conditions. For concept-stage projects, it means the depth and credibility of your technical plan. Both technical and non-technical judges score this criterion — clarity matters as much as sophistication.

Score	Level	What judges will see at this level
1–3	Low	Core functionality is missing, broken, or poorly explained. Little evidence of systems thinking or understanding of how components work together.
4–7	Moderate	Clear structure with functional or credibly designed features. Competent use of tools; main challenges have been considered.
8–10	High	Robust, well-architected design with deliberate technology choices. Handles edge cases, inspires confidence it could be built and maintained professionally.

Tips for a strong score

- Use a simple diagram or walkthrough to show how your components connect.
- Explain why you chose your tech stack — deliberate choices score higher than defaults.
- Demonstrate at least one non-trivial technical decision and why you made it.
- If using AI tools, explain how they fit into the architecture — not just that you used them.

Common pitfalls to avoid

- Don't demo a broken prototype without acknowledging it — judges notice.
- Avoid over-engineering: adding complexity for its own sake signals poor judgment.
- Don't skip error handling or edge cases — 'it works in the demo' isn't enough.
- Non-technical judges can't score what they don't understand — explain it clearly.

Self-Assessment Checklist — Before you submit, can you answer yes to all of these?

- We can explain our architecture clearly to both technical and non-technical judges.
- Our core features work reliably in a demo scenario.
- We can justify our technology choices — not just 'it's what we know'.
- We have thought about what happens when inputs are unexpected or things go wrong.
- A developer unfamiliar with our project could understand and extend it.

UX is evaluated from the perspective of your **actual end users** — often frontline workers under time pressure, shelter residents with varying literacy or tech comfort, or administrators juggling multiple responsibilities. A polished interface designed for developers is not the same as one designed for a shelter intake worker at midnight. Judges will ask: would a real user succeed with this on their first try?

Score	Level	What judges will see at this level
1–3	Low	Interface is confusing, inaccessible, or designed without the real user in mind. Core tasks are hard to find or complete.
4–7	Moderate	Clean and usable. Most target users could navigate core features with brief orientation. Logical flow and clear labelling.
8–10	High	Thoughtfully crafted for the specific audience. Reduces stress, respects user context, and a first-time user can succeed with minimal friction.

Tips for a strong score

- Name your specific user and design for them — not for a generic 'user'.
- Walk through the core task in your demo as if you're that user for the first time.
- Consider accessibility: font size, contrast, plain language, and mobile compatibility.
- Less is more — remove anything that isn't essential for the core user task.

Common pitfalls to avoid

- Don't confuse a beautiful design with a usable one — they're not the same thing.
- Avoid jargon or technical language in the interface that real users won't understand.
- Don't show only the happy path — judges wonder what happens when something goes wrong.
- Designing for a tech-savvy user when your actual user is not will cost you points.

Self-Assessment Checklist — Before you submit, can you answer yes to all of these?

- We can name our specific end user and describe their context (stress, literacy, devices).
- Someone unfamiliar with the project can complete the core task without being guided.
- We have used plain language and avoided technical jargon in the interface.
- The most important actions are obvious and easy to reach.
- We have considered what happens if a user makes a mistake — is recovery easy?
- The design works on the devices and connectivity the real user would have.

A great pitch does three things: it makes judges **care about the problem**, **believe in your solution**, and **trust your team**. You don't need to be a polished speaker — you need to be clear, honest, and compelling. Judges will ask questions, and your answers matter as much as your presentation. The demo should reveal, not just show — what it does, who it's for, and why it works.

Score	Level	What judges will see at this level
1–3	Low	Disorganised, hard to follow, or reads from slides. Demo is unclear or absent. Judges leave uncertain about what was built and why.
4–7	Moderate	Clear structure covering problem, solution, demo, and impact. Audience understands the project. Questions handled adequately.
8–10	High	Compelling narrative with a strong problem opening, polished demo, and confident Q&A; The audience leaves energised and convinced.

Tips for a strong score

- Open with the person, not the product: 'Meet Sarah — she works the night shift at a shelter...'
- Structure your pitch: Problem Solution Demo Impact Ask.
- Practice the demo until it's smooth — even a simple demo delivered confidently scores well.
- Prepare for 2–3 likely judge questions and practice your answers out loud.

Common pitfalls to avoid

- Don't spend more than 20% of your time on background — judges want to see the solution.
- Don't read from slides — speak to the judges, not the screen.
- Avoid vague impact claims ('this will help thousands of people') without any basis.
- Never say 'we ran out of time' — redirect to what you built and what's next.

Self-Assessment Checklist — Before you submit, can you answer yes to all of these?

- Our pitch opens with a specific, relatable problem — not a feature list.
- We have a clear narrative arc: problem solution demo impact.
- Our demo shows the core user task from start to finish.
- Every team member knows the project well enough to answer judge questions.
- We have practiced our pitch at least twice and timed it.
- We can explain our impact clearly without exaggerating or being vague.

Quick Reference — Last-Minute Checklist

Run through this in the final hour before you present.

01	Impact	Can you name the specific problem and explain who it affects and why it matters to the GMHSC community?	☐
02	Feasibility	Have you thought through how this would actually be deployed, maintained, and used beyond today?	☐
03	Innovation	Can you explain what makes your approach different — and why you chose it over the obvious alternatives?	☐
04	Tech Design	Can you walk through your architecture clearly for both a developer and a non-technical judge?	☐
05	UX	Have you tested your demo as if you are your actual end user — not a tech-savvy hackathon participant?	☐
06	Pitch	Does your pitch open with the person, not the product — and do you have your Q&A; answers ready?	☐
07	AI Disclosure	If you used AI tools, have you documented what you used, why, and to what extent?	☐
08	Team Readiness	Can every team member explain the full solution confidently — not just their own piece?	☐

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